Make this soup toward the end of the summer when tomatoes and peppers are plentiful. It freezes well and will be a treat when defrosted for winter meals.

# roasted red pepper, fennel, and tomato soup

**SERVES** 4–6 **PREP** 25 MINS **COOK** 2 HRS **FREEZE** UP TO 2 MONTHS

1 large fennel bulb, peeled
1 red onion
2 red bell peppers, halved and seeded
1lb (500g) tomatoes
4 garlic cloves, in their skins
1½ tsp sugar
2 tbsp olive oil
1 large sprig of fresh rosemary, leaves only
1–2 tbsp vegetable oil
1½ tsp fennel seeds
½ tsp nigella seeds
14fl oz (400ml) passata
1 quart (1 liter) vegetable stock
1 red chile pepper, split and seeded
salt and freshly ground black pepper
handful of fennel leaves

1 Preheat the oven to 400˚F (200˚C). Cut the fennel and onion into wedges. Slice a cross into the base of each tomato and squeeze the juice and seeds into a bowl. Strain the juice and set aside.

2 Line a roasting pan with parchment paper and add the fennel, onion, peppers, tomatoes, and garlic cloves. Sprinkle over the sugar, drizzle with the olive oil, and scatter the rosemary on top. Roast the vegetables for 1 hour, or until the tomatoes are soft. Cool the vegetables before peeling the blackened skin from the peppers. Peel the garlic and discard the skins.

3 Heat the vegetable oil in a large pan and toss in the fennel and nigella seeds, swirling them around for a few seconds. Pour over the passata, the stock, and the reserved tomato juice, and bring to a boil. Add the roasted vegetables, pop the chile pepper into the pan, and season with salt and pepper to taste. Half cover with a lid and simmer for about 45 minutes.

4 Using a blender, process the soup until smooth and press through a sieve. Reheat, re-season, and finish with a sprinkling of fennel leaves.